



Ages 11 to 14

Respect, Sexism and Misogyny

What it is, why it matters, and what you can do. For boys and girls.

Before You Read This guide talks about sexist behaviour, in person and online.

This guide talks about sexist comments, unkind behaviour and harassment, in person and online. Some of it might remind you of something that has happened to you or a friend.

- You can read it a bit at a time, and stop whenever you like.
- If anything worries you, talk to an adult you trust at school or at home.
- **Childline** is free and confidential. You can call 0800 1111 any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.

If you or someone else is in danger right now, tell an adult straight away or call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

This guide is for **boys and girls**. It is about everyone being treated fairly and feeling safe at school, online and in the boarding houses.

- **Most boys and young men treat girls, and each other, with respect.** This is not about blaming anyone.
- Girls are more often the target of sexist and sexual behaviour. **Boys can be targeted too**, and they deserve help as well.
- Everyone can help make things better, and this guide shows you how.

What Do the Words Mean?

Sexism

Treating someone unfairly, or putting them down, because they are a boy or a girl. For example: "Girls can't play football" or "Boys don't cry".

Misogyny

Disliking, looking down on, or being unfair to girls and women, just because they are female.

Sexual harassment

Unwanted comments, jokes, touching, pictures or messages of a sexual kind that make someone feel uncomfortable, embarrassed or scared.

Respect

Treating people as equals: listening to them, taking "no" for an answer, and not putting them down.

What It Can Look Like

In Person

- Jokes that put girls down, or say girls are worse at things
- Comments about someone's body or looks
- "Rating" people on how they look
- Touching someone, or pulling at their clothes, when they don't want it
- Spreading rumours about someone
- Telling boys to "man up", or teasing them for showing feelings

Online

- Group chats full of sexist memes or jokes
- Sharing a picture of someone without asking them
- Fake accounts used to make fun of someone
- Videos from online influencers who say girls and women are worth less than men

- Someone asking you to send a picture of yourself

Is It "Just Banter"?

- Banter is when **everyone** is laughing, including the person it is about, and nobody feels hurt, scared or left out.
- If someone feels upset, uncomfortable, small or afraid, **it is not banter**.
- Ask yourself: would I say this if a teacher was listening? Would I be OK if someone said it about me, or my sister, brother or friend?
- School rules and national guidance are clear: sexual harassment is never "banter", "just having a laugh" or "boys being boys".

How It Affects People

Girls Might

- Feel unsafe or embarrassed at school
- Stop putting their hand up or joining in
- Change how they dress or where they go
- Feel like it's their fault (it isn't)

Boys Might

- Feel pressure to act "tough" or join in to fit in
- Be teased for being kind, quiet or sensitive
- Feel angry or confused by things they see online
- Be targeted too, and feel they can't tell anyone (they can)

Small Things Can Grow

Sexist "jokes" that nobody challenges can slowly turn into harassment, and harassment can get worse. The earlier someone speaks up, the easier it is to stop. You don't need to be certain

something is wrong before you tell an adult.

What the Facts Say

92% and 74%

of girls and boys in secondary schools and colleges said sexist name-calling happens "a lot" or "sometimes" to them or people their age

Ofsted, *Review of sexual abuse in schools and colleges*, 2021

56%

of boys aged 6 to 15 had a negative view of a well-known online influencer who posts sexist content. Most boys in the survey didn't like him.

YouGov, September 2023

Never banter

National guidance for schools says sexual harassment should never be passed off as "banter" or "boys being boys"

Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026

Surveys ask different questions in different ways, so read each figure with its source. Tap a source to check it.

Sources

- Ofsted, *Review of sexual abuse in schools and colleges* (June 2021)
- YouGov Children's Omnibus (September 2023)
- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*

Staying Safe Online

- **Apps show you more of what you watch.** If you watch one video that puts girls down, you will probably be shown more. That doesn't mean everyone thinks that way.
- **Some influencers make money by making people angry.** Ask: who is this person? What do they want from me? Would I talk like this to my friends' faces?
- **Never share a picture of someone without asking them,** and never forward a picture that could embarrass or hurt someone.
- **If someone asks you for a picture of yourself,** or sends you something that worries you, you don't have to reply. Tell an adult you trust.
- **Making, keeping or sharing sexual pictures of anyone under 18 can be a crime,** even pictures someone took of themselves, and even realistic fake or AI-made ones. You won't be blamed for asking for help. If this happens to you, **you are not in trouble for asking for help.**

- **Don't screenshot or forward** a picture like that, even to show an adult. Just tell the adult where it is.
- **Report Remove** (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation) can help get a nude picture of you taken off the internet if you are under 18.
- **CEOP** (ceop.police.uk) is for reporting online sexual abuse, or an adult talking to you online in a way that worries you.

Online Words and Videos: What's Really Going On?

Some words and videos online put girls down or rank boys against each other. They are often shared as jokes, so it can be hard to tell when something has crossed a line.

Words You Might Hear

Sigma, alpha, beta

Labels used to rank boys, often as a joke. Nobody is really an "alpha" or a "beta".

Mogging

Saying someone looks better or "beats" someone else. It is often used to make someone feel small.

Looksmaxxing

Trying to make your looks "perfect". Some of the tips online are unsafe.

Mewing

A way of holding your tongue that some videos say changes your jaw. There is no good evidence that it does.

Top G

A nickname for someone who acts tough or "in charge". It started as one influencer's name for himself.

High value

A way of ranking people by money, muscles or looks. People are not worth more or less because of these.

These words change fast, and people use them in different ways. If you're not sure what something means, it's fine to ask a trusted adult.

"It's Just a Joke"

- Jokes can make unkind ideas feel normal. The more we hear them, the less we notice.
- People sometimes laugh along so they fit in, even when they don't agree.
- You can think a video is silly and still end up repeating its ideas. Notice when that happens.
- If a "joke" makes someone feel small, scared or left out, it isn't just a joke.

Why These Videos Can Feel Appealing

- They can make you feel part of a group.

- They give simple answers to hard questions, like how to be popular or confident.
- They show money, cars and muscles, which can look exciting.
- They are often funny, loud or shocking, so they grab attention.

Wanting to belong and feel confident is normal. You can get those things in ways that don't involve putting anyone down.

The NOISE Check

Before you believe or share a video, check it for NOISE:

N

Negative

Is it trying to make me feel angry, jealous or not good enough?

O

Oppositional

Is it trying to make boys and girls enemies?

I

Insecurity

Is it picking on worries about looks, money or being popular?

S

Simplistic

Does it make a big thing sound easy, or say all girls or all boys are the same?

E

Earnings

Is someone making money if I click, follow or buy?

If a video gets lots of NOISE ticks, it's probably trying to sell you something or wind you up. You don't have to believe it.

RESPOND: What You Can Do

RESPOND is what the adults at school use when they are worried about someone. Here is how it works for students. **You lead the first three steps. Then you stop and think. Then the adults take over.**

You Lead: Relational Steps

R

Recognise

Notice. Trust your feelings.

- Notice if something doesn't feel right, for you or a friend
- Think: **Who** is involved? **Where** is it happening? Is it **online**? Does it keep happening **again and again**?
- You don't need to be sure. If it feels wrong, it's worth talking about

E Engage

Reach out.

- A simple check-in helps: "Are you OK? I noticed what was said."
- If a friend tells you something, **listen without asking for details**. Check they are safe, thank them for telling you, and offer to go with them to a trusted adult
- Say: "I believe you, and I'm taking this seriously."
- **If you see it happening, and it is safe to do so**, you can use the 4Ds: **Direct** (say "That's not OK"), **Distract** (change the subject, call your friend away), **Delegate** (get a trusted adult) or **Delay** (check on your friend afterwards)
- **If it doesn't feel safe to step in, don't.** Get an adult instead

S Support

Be there.

- Ask: "Are you safe right now?"
- Listen without judging. You don't have to fix it
- Stay calm. Being calm helps your friend feel calmer too

The Bridge: Stop and Think

P Pause

Breathe, then decide.

- Take a slow breath before you do anything
- Ask yourself three questions: **Is anyone at risk? What does my friend need? Who can help?**
- Don't promise to keep it a secret, and don't go looking for evidence yourself

Adults Lead: Systems Steps

O Offer

Show them where help is.

- Tell your friend who can help, and offer to go with them
- Show them the better way: respect, kindness and speaking up



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- If a friend tells you about **sexual harassment, abuse, sexual pictures, threats or someone controlling them**, tell a trusted adult soon, **even if they ask you not to**. If you can, tell your friend what you are going to do
- **Telling an adult is not snitching**. It is how people get help
- **Keep being their friend**. Telling an adult doesn't end your part: check in with them, sit with them and include them



Document

Adults write it down.

- The adult will record what happened. You don't need to write anything formal
- Just tell them clearly what you saw, what was said, and what you did



If It's Happening to You

You Are Not to Blame

- It is not your fault. Nobody deserves to be treated this way, whatever they wear, say or do.
- You don't have to deal with it on your own.
- You can tell any adult you trust. If the first person doesn't help, tell someone else.

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with someone you trust**. Behind them is a team whose job is to make sure you get the right help.
- The adult will listen and take what you say seriously.
- If an adult is worried about your safety, they will share the concern with the school's safeguarding team. They will explain what happens next and involve you as much as possible in decisions about keeping you safe. They won't promise to keep it secret.
- Adults who work with young people are allowed to share information that helps keep children safe without asking your permission. They only share what is needed, and only with the people who need to know. They will tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put someone in danger, and they will listen to what you think.

- You will be kept informed about what happens next, and asked what you need.

When It's About More Than One Thing

- Sometimes people are picked on for being a girl **and** for their skin colour, religion or disability, or because someone thinks they are gay, or they don't act "like a boy" or "like a girl".
- That is still not OK, and it is still not your fault. **Tell an adult about all of it**, not just one part.
- Calling someone "gay" or "girl" as an insult is a put-down. It isn't a joke.
- Everyone has the same right to be safe and respected, whatever their background, religion, body or abilities.

Need Help Reading This?

- If reading this guide is hard, ask an adult you trust to go through it with you. You can ask them to explain anything in a different way.

Boys and Girls: What We Can All Do

If You're a Boy

- You can say "that's not OK" when friends make sexist jokes, if it is safe to do so
- You don't have to join in to fit in. Real strength is standing up for others
- If friends egg someone on to boss around, check up on or control a girlfriend or boyfriend, don't join in. Tell an adult
- It's OK to have feelings and talk about them
- If you are being teased or targeted, you can tell an adult too
- If something you see online makes you angry at girls, or bad about yourself, talk to someone about it

If You're a Girl

- You have the right to feel safe and to be heard
- It's not your job to put up with it or laugh it off

- Speaking up about sexist comments is not "overreacting"
- You can support friends by listening and helping them tell an adult

Everyone

- Treat people as equals, in person and online
- Ask first, and accept "no" the first time
- Never share other people's pictures or secrets
- Be an upstander: if it's safe, say something; if not, tell an adult afterwards

If You're Worried About Something You've Done

Everyone makes mistakes. If you're worried about something you've said, shared or done, the best thing is to talk to an adult you trust. You won't be judged for asking for help.

- **Shore** (shorespace.org.uk), run by the Lucy Faithfull Foundation, gives anonymous advice to teenagers worried about their own or someone else's sexual behaviour.
- **Childline** (0800 1111) is there for you too.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's just a joke"	If someone feels hurt, scared or small, it isn't a joke. How it makes them feel matters more than what you meant.
"Boys will be boys"	Nobody is born sexist. It's learned, so it can be unlearned. Most boys are respectful.
"Boys can't be harassed"	Boys can be targeted too, and they deserve help just as much.

"Telling an adult is snitching"	Telling an adult is how people get help and stay safe.
"If you stay quiet, it's not your problem"	Staying quiet can feel like agreeing. Speaking up, or getting an adult, helps.
"Influencers are just saying what everyone thinks"	Most young people don't agree with them. Some influencers earn money by making people angry.



If You Board

Your Boarding House Is Your Home at School

- You should feel safe in your house and your room, just like in class.
- If something happens in your house, even at night, tell a house parent or the member of staff on duty. **You should know how to reach a member of staff at night.** If you don't, ask.
- Sexist jokes, rating lists or unkind group chats in the house are not OK, just like in class.
- Nobody, including older students, should make you do anything to "fit in". Tell a member of staff.
- Follow your house rules for phones at night. If you see something online that upsets or scares you, tell a member of staff: straight away if someone might be in danger, or in the morning if not.
- You can talk to your family in private.

People You Can Talk To

- **You can always contact your house parents, the Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) or a member of the boarding management team,** at any time, day or night.
- Any member of staff in your house or at school
- Your school's **independent listener:** an adult outside the staff you can contact about any worry
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free, confidential, 24/7
- **Help at Hand** (Children's Commissioner, for children living away from home): 0800 528 0731

Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor or advisor, your head of year, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline**: 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- **Report Remove** (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation): to get a nude picture of you removed from the internet, if you are under 18
- **CEOP** ([ceop.police.uk](https://www.ceop.police.uk)): to report online sexual abuse or an adult talking to you online in a way that worries you
- **Shore** ([shorespace.org.uk](https://www.shorespace.org.uk)): anonymous advice about sexual behaviour for teenagers
- **Emergency**: call 999

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Respect, Sexism and Misogyny: Student Guide 101 - 11 to 14

© 2026/27 | **RESPOND** Safeguarding Framework

Contacts and figures checked September 2026 | Next review: September 2027